Information Activism: A Queer History of Lesbian Media Technologies

by Cait McKinney

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Cait McKinney— associate professor in the School of Communication at Simon Fraser University specializing in sexuality studies, media history, and activist media. Their research focuses on the mediated conditions in which queer people, especially activists, have taken up new computing and information technologies to serve their communities and movements. This work surfaces queer modes of technological use that show us alternative ways of understanding technologies and their politics, and offers new media theories and methodologies that emerge from and can account for the knowledges of queer people. Cait is the author of I Know You Are, but What Am I? On Pee-wee Herman (Minnesota 2024) and Information Activism: A Queer History of Lesbian Media Technologies (Duke 2020), which won the Gertrude Robinson Best Book Prize from the Canadian Communication Association and was a Lambda Literary Award Finalist for LGBTQ studies. They are working on a new book, tentatively titled The Sex Lives of Data, which surfaces an original media history of queer digital disruption, a conceptual framework that describes how queer political values such as free sexual expression or justice for HIV+ people distill in specific formal, aesthetic, and technical practices online.

Queer and feminist theorizations of archives and affect seek to account for information's emotional currencies. Archives provide present and future generations with access to information as an affective encounter with the past. Ann Cvetkovich's framing of queer cultural texts as "archives" that become unlikely "repositories of feelings and emotions" has laid tremendous groundwork for understanding "lesbian" as a shared horizon felt in relation to others.[77] Working across affect theory and information studies, appraisal processes, spatial configurations, and reasons for being in the first place are guided by queer affects, including felt, material attachments to histories in which users might find themselves.[78] While scholarship on archives and affect has guided much of my thinking about how archives order or make sense of shared emotion, reading women of color feminism has helped me to think about the relationship between archives and the emotional register of accessing social movement information.

Information activism is motivated by desires for shared history and an erotics of being in proximity to a past organized by sexuality—a history built and occupied by others. The Black lesbian writer and theorist Audre Lorde uses "the erotic" to describe material, affective forms of power that emerge from creating vulnerable connection with others across difference.[79] Lorde's erotic is a way of knowing and being that thrives in the face of exploitative structures.[80] A range of everyday experiences offer erotic connection, "whether it is dancing, building a bookcase, writing a poem, examining an idea."[81] The erotic "is a source of power *and information*" through which women can know the world differently in intimate collaboration.[82] Lorde's use of the term "information" is not generally remarked on in turns to her theory of the erotic. Information implies that the erotic is in part a communication practice: the erotic transmits actionable knowledge between a scene and a woman who has opened herself to this kind of knowledge. This use of "information," combined with Lorde's list of everyday activities, points to the erotic as a transformative, affective practice built out of seemingly unremarkable sites shared with others (information, a bookcase).

Recently, several scholars working at the intersection of critical race and queer studies have taken up Lorde's erotic in relation to affect theory

in ways that have influenced my thinking about information and counterpublics.[83] Amber Jamilla Musser argues that Lorde's erotic provides a model for understanding what drives community formation: "Talking about affect helps displace identity as the basis for community formation and opens political possibilities. Lorde's discussion of the erotic touches on this potential because the most central component of the erotic, after all, is its creation of an affective community. . . This formation of community through affective flows is one of the hallmarks of the plural subject."[84] Guided by the erotic, lesbian feminism's plural subject recognizes others and their distinct histories, joys, and struggles as openings to difference as a ground for knowledge. As an erotic practice, providing access to information is more than just helping divergent publics find what they are looking for; it is a world-making gesture constructed by specific media interfaces and technologies to which users might open themselves. The plural subject brought into lesbian-feminist community often arrives by finding the information she was looking for: where to go, who to talk to, and how. As she arrives to this information, she also learns that others in community came with entirely different questions, histories, interests, and needs.

In media history, information technologies are often constructed as seductive, overwhelming, and powerful, especially when these technologies are new and their introduction promises to deliver new intensities and proximities via communication or information.[85] Brenton J. Malin explains that the "emotional power of communication technologies" is felt most acutely with "*developing* media that seem to be transforming a culture's abilities to connect in ways that can only be imagined."[86] As an active stance generating these kinds of erotic but also identity-based communities, information activism is affective labor that produces collectivity, or the spaces and contexts in which individuals might feel part of something.[87] Information work gives ground to nascent counterpublics by establishing new terms of reference and building shared infrastructures for encountering information.

Affective labor is intrinsically gendered. It is associated most often with domestic and care work's construction as women's work and with digital economies that celebrate the "flexibility" of working from home.[88] Feminist activist labor and volunteer work present another kind of "second shift," often done on the fly or in the margins of one's "spare time." Worked on

within these temporalities, information technologies become sites of infiltration, appropriation, and resourcefulness for marginalized users. These are the tactics through which feminists usurp or appropriate technology toward collective ways of doing politics, out of urgency and love.

While affective labor is often understood as immaterial, particularly in its digital manifestations, information activists emphasize the hypermaterial aspects of activism performed with media technologies as they work across digital and "analog" forms.[89] Lesbian feminists who made print resources or sat at desks night after night, working the hotline phones, carved pathways through information that others without prior access might follow. Indexing is a material form of affective labor, whether it is performed with paper cards or computers, because the practice assembles people, information, and technologies toward social goals.[90] Information activism brings together people marginalized from access to these resources, pushing on the divisions that can bifurcate information and emotion in the first place.

When finding information means finding deeply needed forms of support, the experience can offer transformative invitation to community. But lesbian feminism has also promoted and practiced painful exclusions, leaving behind legacies of white supremacy and trans exclusion that live on in the present. These conflicts in late twentieth-century lesbian-feminist organizing have been well documented by scholars studying histories of feminist theory, the institutionalization of women's studies, transgender organizing, and women of color feminism.[91] Unpacking these acrimonious histories matters because of how they persist in contemporary "LGBTQ" or queer women's activist spaces centered on whiteness and cis-normativity, or committed to homogenizing difference through an additive framework that simply invites more people to the same lousy table.[92]

This book asks how conflicts over difference are worked out through everyday decisions lesbian feminists make when they design and work within information infrastructures. Activist work with information can shore up what kind of lesbian life counts as a life worth serving on the phone or preserving in an archive. Work with information can put into practice antiracism, for example, through the *Black Lesbians* (1981) bibliographic project I examine in chapter 3. This text built an information infrastructure that centered Black women in lesbian history, making their leadership undeniable. As the Black writer Barbara Smith put it in her foreword, the bibli-

ography generated "the excitement of finally having a substantial body of information on Black lesbians."[93] "From the bibliography it is historically verifiable that it was Black feminist/lesbian women who consistently and courageously raised the issue of racism from the beginning of the women's movement, finally pushing white women to make anti-racist work a priority in the late 1970s."[94] By organizing this history into a quick reference list of resources women could use for future research, *Black Lesbians* showed users another way forward, beyond whiteness as an unacknowledged center for lesbian history.

Smith wrote that the bibliography can "inspire us Black lesbians to write about and to manifest our lives in every way possible."[95] Sara Ahmed has described a "lesbian feminism of color" that recognizes "the struggle to put ourselves back together because within lesbian shelters too our being was not always accommodated."[96] Some information infrastructures have constructed uninhabitable shelters that ought to be torn down and rebuilt, while others have offered lesbians of color these tools of assembly.

Studying late twentieth-century lesbian-feminist social movement archives often means confronting transphobia and transmisogyny at the level of organizational policy or as regular speech acts made between activists. At their best, these movement archives also document the mundane ways lesbian feminists carved out spaces for trans people with the choices they make about information. As Susan Stryker has argued, "There was nothing monolithic about second wave feminist attitudes toward trans issues. The feminist second wave simultaneously espoused some of the most reactionary attitudes toward trans people to be found anywhere while also offering a vision of transgender inclusion in progressive feminist movements for social change."[97] Recent transfeminist histories have developed less polarizing, multivalent studies about trans participation in "second-wave" feminist movements.[98] Finn Enke asks why stories of trans exclusion and abjection have been so "magnetic" and implores feminist historians to think about the cultural work these narratives perform and the "generations of scholars and activists who need more than easy critiques of exclusion."[99] Sometimes trans exclusion or solidarity happens in uneven, everyday ways, through seemingly minor choices about information design.

These choices include how to describe materials or people in a database or whether or not to help a trans woman in need who calls a telephone

hotline. The purpose of accounting for trans people's places on the margins of lesbian feminist history is not to search out ways in which trans people might become politically aligned with lesbian community, a "habitual assumption" in social movement studies critiqued by Viviane Namaste.[100] Rather, I argue that understanding how radical feminist movements regard trans people through the design and provision of information can show us how particular ideas about gender inform infrastructure design and determine how care is provisioned at a technological level. Historicizing these decisions matters because the complex lineages between lesbian and transfeminist ideas still need to be fleshed out and because lesbian groups and spaces that want to do better must continue to learn from these histories at the level of their information design.

As Ahmed writes, "It is transfeminism today that most recalls the militant spirit of lesbian feminism in part because of the insistence that crafting a life is political work."[101] Ahmed's words insist that lesbian feminism has some kind of present-day urgency despite this movement's apparent untimeliness—what Elizabeth Freeman has called the feeling of "temporal drag" lesbians elicit in the present. Lesbian feminism is out of fashion, yet it's being revived through critical projects that include Instagram history accounts, contemporary throwback clothing, museum shows, and scholarly research. Information precarity motivated past generations of information activists but does not define these new projects in the same ways. In response to the threat of complete erasure, 1970s and '80s information activists produced abundant archival conditions that facilitate enlivenments of lesbian feminist history via digital networks today. Put simply, young people are sifting through digital collections to discover and recirculate lesbian feminist iconography. While lesbian information is no longer so precarious, the fervor of these digital "archives" materializes an ongoing, urgent drive to imagine, critique, and repurpose information from the past.

Lesbian feminism is not a visible social movement with a firm set of aesthetic and actionable commitments anymore, yet it continues to guide these projects and the principles of organizations such as the LHA. Founded in 1974, this archives is staffed not only by women in their sixties and seventies who came to activism during the civil rights and women's liberation movements, but also by a growing contingent of young folks in their twenties born under the sign of queerness. This younger generation

often brings commitments to transfeminism or queer politics, even as they revel in "deep-lez" desires to understand and embody butch-femme dynamics and terminologies or wear labrys necklaces without irony.[102] They are motivated by lesbian activist history even as they do not quite occupy its terms. Women who have worked at the archives for decades have their own, evolving relationships to lesbian politics and do not think about gender today the way they did forty years ago. As a queer history of information, this book shares with these volunteers a comfort with the messiness among feminist, queer, transfeminist, and lesbian-feminist histories and their surprising temporalities.[103]

How these ideals shape the organization's archiving practices is one example of lesbian feminism's ongoing effects on information infrastructures. This "historical" movement continues to exert affective pull on the present and on "queer" subjects.[104] This pull has been mediated, past and present, through lesbian-feminist work with technology as it shapes the ongoing stakes of access to information. An exciting body of literature has worked to historicize late-twentieth-century feminist history from the present through the rubric of affect theory.[105] Put broadly, this scholarship asks what historical feminisms *do* in the present when we remember, study, or otherwise enliven them. Here, ambivalent feelings about feminisms of the past are held open: accusations of essentialism, normativity, single-issue politics, and racism leveled at lesbian feminism become potentially productive obstacles because of their continued relevance and pressure in the present.[106] As Victoria Hesford explores, it is precisely these antagonisms and the ambivalence they engender that give the women's liberation movement boundaries and contours, making it nameable as a phenomenon both during its operation and from the present.[107] This work challenges the celebration of queer as inherently progressive and unmarred by these concerns and questions queer studies' search for only those historical objects that serve the field's political goals.[108]

I foreground ambivalence because to some extent my ambivalent identifications with lesbian feminism are at the center of this media history. As a researching subject bringing together a particular set of objects toward historiographic ends, I have tried to foreground my desiring attachments to this work, these women, and this political movement. Beginning in the

LHA basement, I include my "archive stories" about coming to and moving among the objects and actors that make up my archive here.[109] Doing this work has asked me to reckon with my own attachments to lesbian feminism and even to the category "lesbian." I have moved through this research and the spaces it has brought me to with frequent uncertainty about how my nonbinary gender identity and commitments to transfeminist practice might fit—all this despite wanting to occupy some relation to lesbian and caring deeply about lesbian feminism's ongoing place in digital archives of the ever-unfolding present.

The Internet That Lesbians Built

Newsletter Networks

Julia Penelope, a professor of English at the University of Nebraska, described herself as a "white, working-class, fat butch dyke who never passed."[1] She challenged universities and their conservative structures. Before landing at Lincoln, she was kicked out of two different graduate schools and fired from one academic appointment because of homophobia.[2] A political lesbian separatist, Penelope edited several collected volumes of writings on lesbianism, but one of her greatest contributions to lesbian-feminist politics begins with a modest, mimeographed letter sent to other researchers in the Spring of 1977. Addressed "Dear Sister," the letter proposes a newsletter to be circulated to academics, activists, artists, and community researchers across the United States working on lesbian-feminist topics, mostly historical in focus. The letter begins,

> Several wimmin across the U.S. have been corresponding back and forth, exchanging papers, and we've been considering starting a Lesbian/Feminist Research Newsletter that would facilitate communication among the members of what we perceive to be a growing network of wimmin doing exciting research on issues and problems that touch on all of our lives. Right now, our communication is haphazard, and we don't always know who's doing what research. A newsletter would help to keep us in touch with each other, and inform us of recent papers and publications and ongoing research.[3]

That fall, Penelope collaborated with four other women spread across the country—Libby Bouvier, Sarah Hoagland, JR Roberts, and Susan Leigh

Star—to found *Matrices: A Lesbian/Feminist Research Newsletter*. In a classic feminist move toward diverting institutional resources, Penelope asked her department chair, John Robinson, whether the department would fund the newsletter, and he agreed. It was produced using the department's photocopier and distributed free of charge until 1982, when a modest subscription fee was instituted. Circulation had increased to "800 womyn in nearly every state and seven countries" by the newsletter's fourth year of publication.[4] *Matrices* bridged the worlds of academic lesbian studies and community research, attuned to a lesbian-feminist politics of class-consciousness and institutional critique. Subscribers and contributors included artists and academics who made major interventions in queer and feminist scholarship, from Jonathan Katz, the gay and lesbian historian and founder of OutHistory.org, to the fiction writer Sarah Schulman and lesbian-feminist filmmaker Barbara Hammer.

[...]

Newsletters as Information Activism

Matrices is one among several newsletters that provided communicative support for grassroots lesbian historical research. Often called simply "lesbian studies," this field grew in the 1980s out of the more established women's history movement and the nascent gay and lesbian history field.[10] Other newsletters that had a similar focus include the *Lesbian/Gay History Researchers Network Newsletter* (1980–81) and the annual newsletter of the Lesbian Herstory Archives (1975–2004). A loosely organized community of academics, noninstitutional researchers, and activists working to redress the elision of gay and lesbian experience from the historical record established community archives across the United States and Canada and conducted primary source research and publication.[11]

Several intersecting politics form the movement's ideological roots: the post-Stonewall gay liberation movement is key, as is the longer legacy of the midcentury Homophile Movement, particularly its middle-class, assimilationist investment in the free circulation of gay and lesbian literature depicting "accurate" information about homosexuality. Lesbian-feminist historical organizations also emerged out of the women's liberation movement in the 1970s, as did new university women's studies departments and feminist oral history methods. Organizations such as the Lesbian Herstory Archives (LHA) straddled both worlds. Run by feminist activists who came of age in the women's liberation era, the archives also found an uneasy home in the larger world of gay and lesbian community archives noted for emphasizing white gay men's histories.

Community archives such as the LHA constructed and maintained mailing lists to extend the reach of their work beyond the physical building and those women able to visit New York. The archives bought their first computer and database software in 1984 to manage this growing mailing list. The LHA understood the transition to computerized information management as networked outreach even as the computer itself was not, in technical terms, "networked."[12] Mailed newsletters performed outreach that was critical to fledgling gay and lesbian archives for a few reasons. First, newsletters sought funding from the community to run archives. Fundraising helped to pay rent and utilities, buy supplies, and reduce the financial

burden shouldered by volunteers, who paid for many archives activities out of pocket. Second, newsletters reported research findings and alerted readers to publication of this research. Third, and key to my analysis here, newsletters told potential researchers what was available in archives, providing the information infrastructure needed to use collections. The resulting publications served the historical movement's ultimately pedagogical goal: connecting marginalized counterpublics with the histories they craved but could not find.[13]

I found *Matrices*—or maybe it found me—during my research period at the LHA studying the archives' digitization practices. I was at the archives on a Saturday afternoon in my capacity as a volunteer, sorting through a stack of donor agreement forms. I was creating a spreadsheet to identify which collections of personal and organizational papers had the go-ahead to be listed online. On Saturdays, the archives is staffed by founder Deb Edel, and her partner, Teddy Minucci.

Edel and I were sitting at the large, shared worktable in the archives' main-floor library, talking about how my research was going. I told her I had begun to think that I needed a longer history of lesbians and technology at the archives if I was going to really understand the politics behind their current digitization projects. We talked more generally about my interest in print newsletters and the communicative work the archives performed. Edel told me how feminist social movement organizations, including the LHA, relied on networks of their own, albeit predigital ones. All of a sudden, a light seemed to go off in her head. There was a publication she wanted to show me. The name was on the tip of her tongue. Edel led me up the stairs to the periodicals room and went straight to the Hollinger box that contained nearly every issue of *Matrices*. She didn't need to check a computer to find out where the box was; she just knew from decades spent organizing these shelves.

I spent some time with the newsletter that day and found myself returning to it each time I was in New York during that research year. Meanwhile, *Matrices* and the people who used the publication to communicate kept surfacing as I continued my research on lesbian-feminist information activism. For example, when the LHA launched its digital audio site, the first tapes made available as streaming audio were drawn from Madeline Davis and Elizabeth Kennedy's Buffalo Women's Oral History Project.[14] From

An Annotated Bibliography both appear as works in progress in the pages of *Matrices* and the *Lesbian Herstory Archives Newsletter*. Later I learned that Julia Penelope—that "white, working-class, fat butch dyke who never passed"—was a member of the five-woman collective who founded the LHA, four years before she wrote the letter that launched *Matrices*.

I realized gradually through my immersion in the worlds of these intertwined media technologies, people, and events that *Matrices* exemplified how lesbian-feminist information infrastructures are built and sustained through networks that facilitate collaboration and resource-sharing amid precarious conditions. *Matrices* became a way to consider some of the more interstitial media that made lesbian-feminist organizing possible. Although it was not affiliated with any single archives, *Matrices* supported emerging community archives, publishing requests for donations of funds and primary source materials and making potential researchers aware of collections they could access. *Matrices* is one outlet in a complex web of print-based communications that allowed these archives to operate and that, by extension, allowed researchers to find information about lesbian history.

Matrices was published three times a year from 1977 until the mid-1980s and then infrequently until 1996. In the early 1990s, many print newsletters lost relevance as web browsing developed and email listservs became key networks for sharing information in both feminist social movement organizing and humanities and social science research communities.[15] While studying *Matrices* I closely analyzed a total of twenty-four issues gathered from partial collections at two different periodicals collections. My method of close reading across issues emphasizes the people, projects, spaces, and conversations that transcend individual issues rather than focusing on any of the publication's singular moments. For example, the New Alexandria Lesbian Library in western Massachusetts appears in the pages of the publication beginning in 1978. Updates chronicle New Alexandria's initial conception and fundraising drive to its move from Chicago and search for new volunteer staff. The library's short listings in *Matrices*—generally a few paragraphs in length—updated readers (who were also potential donors, volunteers, and researchers) on the project's status and told them about the sources available at the library. These listings also solicited input on the collection's direction from the *Matrices* community.

Today New Alexandria has evolved into the Sexual Minorities Archives, run by Ben Power Alwin, a trans man who inherited the collection when the original lesbian collective dissolved in 1978. As the transgender archives scholar K. J. Rawson notes, Alwin transitioned the collection to an "all-inclusive" LGBTQI archives alongside his own transition in the early 1990s.[16] For Rawson, this shift reflects broader movements away from gay and lesbian toward LGBTQ+, but more interestingly, it shows that archival collections, like the people stewarding them, have individual identities that are adaptable. The Lesbian Herstory Archives' ongoing grounding in the lesbian community and collective organizational structure maintain the focus on *lesbian* materials, even as the meaning of this category changes. Following New Alexandria's activities through *Matrices* over a period of years illustrates the publication's ongoing entanglement with a larger, evolving activist movement and its instrumental role in facilitating outreach. But as Alwin's work reminds us, these networks also extend into the present and can depart from their lesbian-feminist entanglements.

In addition to reading across the *Matrices* archive, my method situates the publication in a larger constellation of feminist and lesbian-feminist periodicals by following citation practices across other newsletters.[17] Reading *Matrices* as a network is necessarily retrospective, requiring a larger view of how various efforts at making history drew on one another in a united movement. Seeing this network from the present also depends on feminist libraries and archives with open-access policies that allow me to bring these publications into conversation with one another. I am literally describing the ability of a researcher at the LHA or York University's tiny Women and Gender Studies Library to sort through open stacks of rare feminist printed matter—newsletters that would be gated behind rare books desks and doled out one box at a time at most institutions. At these collections I could bring issues from a few different publications over to a table and look at them together. I could let the pages touch. Open access to periodicals collections allows feminist researchers to follow a citation by pulling out more than one publication at the same time. Policies that open the stacks allow for material entanglements among texts, scenes, people, and geographies. For Kate Eichhorn, this methodological proximity is rooted in a feminist, open-access archival politics that makes collaborative, network-based feminist histories possible.[18] Libraries and archives practice

network-based feminist histories possible.[18] Libraries and archives practice access and classification strategies that are critical to the preservation of feminist networks, which might not otherwise survive the isolating disciplinary technologies of archival accumulation.[19] In other words, activist archives require activist archival methods to maintain the intelligibility of the larger relationships they made possible.//

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